

Open Word Bible

A free translation of the Bible from Hebrew and Greek, with the reasoning behind every sentence.

Open Word Bible translates the Scriptures from their original languages into modern languages, English and Spanish first, and releases everything into the public domain. Its distinguishing feature is transparency: a reader can open any sentence and see the original words, a word-for-word gloss, and every translation decision with the alternatives considered and the reason for the choice.

1. VISION

Most modern Bible translations are copyrighted. That limits who can quote, print, adapt, put them in apps, or build new resources on them. And almost every translation makes thousands of interpretive choices silently: the reader sees the result, never the reasoning.

Open Word Bible aims to change both:

- **Free for everyone.** The translation, its notes and its data are released under CC0. Anyone may use them for any purpose without asking permission.
- **The work is shown.** Every sentence carries a reasoning record that explains how the original was understood and why it was worded as it is.
- **For every reader.** Three reading levels and a small set of reader settings let people choose how the text reads without changing what it means.
- **Many languages, one understanding.** The meaning of each passage is worked out once and shared by every language, so translations stay consistent with each other.

2. THE APPROACH

Translated from the original languages

Every language is translated from the Hebrew, Aramaic and Greek, never from English. English may be consulted as a guide, but it is never the source. The source texts are fixed, openly licensed editions, pinned to exact versions so that every result can be reproduced.

ROLE	SOURCE	LICENCE
Old Testament text	Westminster Leningrad Codex	Public domain
Old Testament word data	Open Scriptures Hebrew Bible; MACULA Hebrew	CC BY 4.0
New Testament text	SBL Greek New Testament (v1.2)	CC BY 4.0
New Testament word data	MACULA Greek (lemma, grammar, glosses)	CC BY 4.0
Consulted, not followed	Byzantine and Received Texts; Septuagint; Dead Sea Scrolls	Cited in notes

One firm rule protects accuracy: **the original-language text is never typed by hand.** Every Hebrew and Greek word, in the text and in the notes, is pulled from the source data by software. In early testing, Greek typed from memory contained accent errors that this rule now prevents.

Three reading levels

LEVEL	AIM	CHARACTER
Literal (OWB-L)	Let readers see the original's form	Follows the original's wording and order where English allows; added words shown in brackets

LEVEL	AIM	CHARACTER
Balanced (OWB-B)	Natural and accurate; the default	Reads like modern English while tracking the original closely
Readable (OWB-R)	Plain language for new and young readers	Short sentences, idioms explained, about a 6th–8th grade reading level

The levels may differ in how much they say, but never in what they mean. A level may keep an ambiguity the original has, but no level may choose a different reading from the others. Key theological terms such as *grace*, *glory*, *covenant* and *righteousness* stay the same at every level.

Reasoning records: showing the work

Each sentence has a record containing the original words with their grammar, a word-for-word gloss, the translation at each level, and a list of decisions. Each decision states the words it covers, the choice made, the alternatives considered, and the reason in plain language. Decisions sit in two layers:

LAYER	WRITTEN	SHARED BY	COVERS
Meaning	Once per passage	Every language and level	Manuscript readings, word senses, grammar, allusions, idioms, culture, theology
Rendering	Once per language and level	That language only	Word choice, word order, style, words added for sense

EXAMPLE: JOHN 1:1, "THE WORD WAS GOD"	
Original	θεὸς ἦν ὁ λόγος
Choice	"the Word was God"
Also considered	"the Word was a god"; "the Word was divine"
Reason	"The Word" has the article, so it is the subject. "God" comes first without the article and says what the Word is, without making the Word the same person as "the God" just mentioned. "A god" would contradict John's insistence on one God; "divine" is weaker than the noun.

Notes are written at the same time as the translation, not afterwards as justification; they cite only sources the project holds; and where the evidence is evenly balanced, the decision is marked *uncertain*.

3. KEY DECISIONS

QUESTION	DECISION	WHY
Name and domain	Open Word Bible; openwordbible.org	"Word" points to Scripture and to the Word of John 1
Licence	CC0 for translation, notes and data; MIT for code	Removes every barrier to use and reuse
New Testament base	SBL Greek New Testament	Modern critical text, openly licensed; major variants given in footnotes
Default level	Balanced	Matches the most widely read modern translations
Divine name	"the LORD" by default; "Yahweh" as a setting	Familiar tradition, with the personal name one tap away
Gender language	Inclusive where the original includes women; Traditional as a setting	Says what the original means to a modern reader; God, Christ and named men are never changed
Spelling	US by default; UK as a setting	Largest English readership
Disputed passages	Printed in brackets with a note (e.g. Mark 16:9–20)	Neither hidden nor presented as certain

Reader settings: wording, never meaning

Settings change only how something is said, never what it means. Where scholars disagree about meaning (for example, Isaiah 7:14), there is no setting: the translation commits to one reading and the notes give the others.

Divine name: the LORD · Yahweh | **Gender:** Inclusive · Traditional | **Units and money:** modern · original | **Christos:** Christ · Messiah | **Pronouns for God:** he · He | **Spelling:** US · UK | **Spanish plural "you":** ustedes · vosotros. Defaults are listed first.

Each setting is stored once inside the text as a marked alternative, so a setting never needs its own translation or review. Passages that are cited, printed, downloaded or shared with other sites always use the defaults, under a stable edition code (OWB-L, OWB-B, OWB-R).

4. MANY LANGUAGES

English comes first, followed by Spanish, then French, Portuguese and Swahili, and more as reviewers are found. The two-layer design is what makes this practical. When the English and Spanish versions of John 1:1-18 were compared, all 35 meaning decisions carried over to Spanish unchanged. Spanish needed only 12 new decisions of its own instead of a fresh set of 48.

The Spanish test also showed why each language needs its own rendering layer. Problems appeared that English never faces:

- **Grammatical gender.** "La Palabra" (the Word) is feminine, but the Word becomes a man in John 1:14, so the traditional masculine "el Verbo" was chosen and flagged for native review.
- **Two verbs for one.** Spanish must split the Greek "was" into *era* (identity) and *estaba* (presence).
- **Inclusive by grammar.** Spanish *hijos* and *hermanos* already include women, so they need no gender setting.
- **Regional forms.** Spanish needs *ustedes* or *vosotros*; a single setting covers both, even changing verb forms such as *alégrense* / *alegraos*.

For languages with few speakers or little written material, the project should partner with established Bible translation organisations rather than rely on AI alone. AI translation is strong in major languages and unreliable in low-resource ones.

5. REVIEW AND HONESTY

Every passage is first drafted with AI assistance. Nothing is marked reviewed until named people approve it, and the AI never approves its own work. Readers always see where a passage stands.

Every passage moves through four statuses: **AI draft** (not yet reviewed); **meaning reviewed** (checked by a reviewer trained in Hebrew or Greek); **reviewed** (also checked by a fluent reader of the target language); and **revised** (changed after review, with the reason recorded).

Two further safeguards: anyone can flag a sentence for correction, and every accepted change records who made it, when and why. New text is also checked against well-known copyrighted translations. In testing, early drafts of Philippians 4:6-8 came out almost word for word like existing translations and were rewritten.

6. TECHNOLOGY

Data first, website second. The core product is an open dataset, not a website. Each passage is a structured file of sentence records; the public site, an app, Ochorus and any other project all read from the same versioned releases, published in standard Bible formats (USFM, USX) and JSON.

Checks on every change. Automated tests (35 today) verify that every word reference exists in the source data, that the Greek matches the data exactly, that settings are well formed, and that sentences crossing verse boundaries are marked correctly.

A simple, sturdy site. The reader site is plain static pages built by a short Python script and hosted on Render at openwordbible.org: no database and no server code, so it is cheap to run and hard to break. It works on phones and in light and dark modes.

Technical issues still to solve: Hebrew support (right-to-left text and Old Testament word data); translating the notes themselves into each language; a repeatable pipeline that drafts whole books rather than passages; a reviewer workflow with sign-off recorded in the data; and automated similarity checks against copyrighted versions.

7. WHERE THINGS STAND

Done

- Translation charter agreed, covering the decisions on this page.
- Source licences confirmed from each dataset's own licence file.
- John 1:1-18 and Philippians 4:1-9 in English and Spanish, at all three levels, with about 120 reasoning notes.
- Data format, checker, tests and a reader website, ready to deploy.

Not yet

- No passage has been reviewed by a human scholar.
- The site is not yet live.
- Notes are in English only.
- No Old Testament (Hebrew) passage yet.
- No complete book yet.

8. THE PLAN

PHASE	WORK	OUTCOME
1. Foundation	Launch the site; set up reviewer sign-off; recruit Greek, Hebrew and Spanish reviewers; add a Hebrew sample (Genesis 6)	A public draft that experts can review
2. First book	Build the drafting pipeline; translate a complete Gospel (Mark or John) in English and Spanish; translate the notes	A usable, reviewable book in two languages
3. First release	Publish version 0.1 of the open dataset; show verse pop-ups for Scripture references in Ochorus	Others can build on the work
4. Growth	The New Testament, then the Old Testament; French, Portuguese and Swahili; partnerships for smaller languages	A full, free, transparent Bible in many languages

9. RISKS AND OPEN QUESTIONS

- **Trust.** An AI-assisted Bible will be met with scepticism. The answer is full transparency, named human reviewers, and never overstating what has been checked.
- **Reviewer capacity.** Review, not drafting, is the real limit on speed. Recruiting qualified reviewers is the most important early task.
- **Theological positioning.** Some churches will ask for a statement of faith before adopting the text. Whether to publish one, or only the charter, is still open.
- **Contested choices.** Defaults such as inclusive gender language will be debated. Every such choice is explained, and the alternative is always one tap away.
- **Low-resource languages.** These require partnership with experienced translation organisations, not AI alone.

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